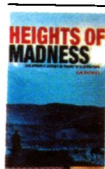


COLD COMFORT

Armed with clichés, a British journalist travels to the highest battlefield to report the futility of a conflict



HEIGHTS OF MADNESS: ONE WOMAN'S JOURNEY IN PURSUIT OF A SECRET WAR
by MYRA MACDONALD
Rupa
Price: Rs 395, Pages: 242

■ By Sam Miller

High up in the Himalayas, is a huge glacier—the largest outside the polar regions—and known at one time, because it was so inhospitable and remote, as ‘The Third Pole’. Siachen is now more usually described as ‘the highest battlefield in the world’, and has become a symbol of intransigence and wastefulness. Billions of rupees have been frittered away by Pakistan and India on a conflict that neither side believes it can win. Thousands of soldiers have died or been maimed, defending an enormous lump of ice which serves no discernable strategic purpose.

After the first Kashmir war of 1947-48, a ceasefire line was not demarcated across this part of the disputed territory—and the wording of the 1949 Karachi ceasefire agreement is ambiguous. Neither side, at that time, saw the occupation of the glacier as a potential military or national objective. The Siachen dispute did not really surface until 1984, when India set up its first defensive positions on the glacier—partly as a response to Pakistan allowing a series of foreign mountaineering expeditions into the area. There were serious military clashes on the glacier throughout the 1980s and 1990s, as well as long-running artillery and sniper campaigns which cost many lives. In 2003, a ceasefire was declared, but the appalling weather on the glacier continues to kill soldiers on both sides.

British journalist Myra MacDonald—who was based in Delhi for several years—is one of the few people to have been up to Siachen with both the Indian and Pakistani armies. This engaging book tells of her attempts to get permission to visit the glacier, her eventful journeys by road

and helicopter, and her interviews with current and former soldiers. She intersperses these with some rather run-of-the-mill journalistic tales of the modern subcontinent—including her struggles with the Indian bureaucracy, a visit to the site of the demolished Babri Masjid, an exposition of female foeticide in Haryana, and a soliloquy on the perils of encountering monkeys on the streets of Delhi.

MacDonald considers the conflict over Siachen to be absurd and futile. But she is full of admiration for the unfortunate soldiers who live and fight there at over 18,000 ft, “a height so unsuited to sustaining human life that the body has to feed on itself in order to

would have “to do better than describe snow as white”. This seems to have encouraged MacDonald to become besotted with adjectives, as if she were satirising a college creative-writing exercise. The Nubra river is first “delicate and meandering”, then “winsome and erratic” and finally “wistful, innocent, self-effacing”. I almost wished she had described it as wet. Remote places in the mountains are always “Shangri-La”. She also misquotes Shakespeare, misspells Tolkien, and tells us, erroneously, that RSS was banned “for years” after the assassination of Mahatma Gandhi.

MacDonald is pleasantly surprised on finally arriving in Pakistan for the



GLACIER GLIMPSE: MacDonald (left) has only admiration for the soldiers

survive”. And her book has many telling little observations: how pain is intensified by the cold, and just how boring it is. MacDonald comes across as a warm and irrepressible reporter, gently puncturing military pomposity and bureaucratic inertia with an endearing clumsiness and honesty. She is always aware how strange she must seem to the soldiers—a white woman, wandering around these all-male bastions in a frozen wasteland.

She notes in the introduction to *Heights of Madness* that a friend who read an early draft told her that she

first time: “Islamabad airport was clean, modern and organised. It was like arriving in a developed country rather than in the failed state India had sought to portray.” But she finds in Pakistan’s sense of being both a victim and a great nuclear power, “a schizophrenic identity that left many Pakistanis floundering”. Overall, MacDonald seeks to be even-handed with India and Pakistan—cursing both houses over the undoubted pointlessness of the Siachen conflict. Jorge Luis Borges’ terse summing-up of the Falklands war is even more apt as a comment on the Siachen dispute: “Two bald men fighting over a comb.” ■